

— THE EVIDENCE-BASED LIBRARY

Nutrition Fundamentals

The science-based system for eating to build muscle, lose fat and get stronger — without the guesswork, fad diets or overwhelm.

Calories & macros

Meal building

Labels & supplements

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A Premium Guide

— WELCOME

Let's take the guesswork out of eating.

Most beginners don't fail from a lack of effort. They fail because nobody ever gave them a complete system — just conflicting advice, extreme diets and rules that fall apart after a fortnight.

This guide fixes that. In the next few pages you'll learn exactly how food works, how to set your numbers, and how to build meals that fit your life. No banned foods. No overwhelm. Just a clear, repeatable process you can run for the rest of your life.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE**Read in order**

Each section builds on the last. Start at calories and work forward.

**Do the actions**

Every chapter ends with a step. The checklist on page 13 ties it together.

**Keep it close**

Come back to the tables and swaps whenever you shop or plan a week.



This is a system, not a diet. Nothing here expires in 30 days. Learn the principles once and you'll never need another meal-plan gimmick again.

— INSIDE THIS GUIDE

What you'll learn

01	Calories explained	04	07	Reading nutrition labels	10
02	Protein	05	08	Hydration & supplements	11
03	Carbohydrates & fats	06	09	Common mistakes	12
04	Calculate your numbers	07	10	Action checklist	13
05	Building balanced meals	08	11	Summary & next steps	14
06	Food swaps	09			

Everything here is built on the same principles we use with 1:1 coaching clients — simplified into a self-guided reference you can act on today.

— THE FOUNDATION

Calories: the master switch

A calorie is simply a unit of energy. Whether you gain, lose or maintain weight comes down to one thing above all else: **energy balance** — the calories you eat versus the calories you burn. Every diet that has ever worked, works because of this.

Deficit**Eat < you burn**

Your body taps stored fat for energy. This is how you **lose fat**.

Maintenance**Eat = you burn**

Weight holds steady. Great for holding gains and taking a break.

Surplus**Eat > you burn**

Extra energy fuels **muscle growth** (train hard, or it's just fat).

HOW MUCH ENERGY IS IN FOOD?**4**

kcal / g protein

4

kcal / g carbs

9

kcal / g fat

7

kcal / g alcohol



Key idea: You don't need to fear any single food. You need to control the total. Master calories first — everything else is fine-tuning.

— MACRONUTRIENT 01

Protein: build & repair

Protein is the raw material your body uses to build and repair muscle. It's also the most filling macro and costs the most energy to digest — which makes it your single most important lever for changing your body composition.

1.6–2.2

grams per kg bodyweight, daily

4

kcal per gram

3–4

meals to spread it across

Why it matters

- ✓ Preserves muscle in a fat-loss phase and builds it in a surplus
- ✓ Keeps you fuller for longer, so you eat less without trying
- ✓ Burns more calories to digest than carbs or fat

Best sources

Chicken & turkey

Lean beef

Fish & seafood

Eggs

Greek yoghurt

Cottage cheese

Tofu & tempeh

Lentils & beans

Whey / soy protein

Rule of thumb: aim for a palm-sized portion of protein at every meal. Hit your daily protein target and you've won most of the nutrition battle.

— MACRONUTRIENTS 02 & 03

Carbohydrates & fats

Once protein is set, carbs and fats fuel your training and keep your body running. Neither is the enemy — you simply divide your remaining calories between them based on preference and performance.



Carbohydrates

Your main training fuel · 4 kcal/g

Carbs power hard workouts and aid recovery. Base most of your intake on minimally processed sources.

BEST SOURCES

Rice & pasta

Oats

Potatoes

Fruit

Wholegrains



Fats

Hormones & health · 9 kcal/g

Fats support hormones, brain function and vitamin absorption. They're calorie-dense, so portion them with care.

BEST SOURCES

Olive oil

Nuts & seeds

Avocado

Oily fish

Nut butters

Carb target: roughly 3–5 g/kg on training days — more if you train hard, less on rest days.

Fat floor: keep fats at ~0.6–1 g/kg (never below ~20% of calories) to protect hormones.

— PUT IT TOGETHER

Calculate your calories & macros

Five steps takes you from bodyweight to a full daily target. Use these as a smart starting point, then adjust based on real-world results over 2–3 weeks.

- 1 Estimate maintenance.** Bodyweight (kg) × 30–33 kcal is a solid starting estimate for most active people.
- 2 Set your goal.** Fat loss: –15–20%. Muscle gain: +10%. Maintenance: leave it as is.
- 3 Protein first.** Set ~2 g/kg bodyweight. Multiply grams × 4 to get protein calories.
- 4 Then fats.** Set ~0.8 g/kg. Multiply grams × 9 to get fat calories.
- 5 Carbs fill the rest.** Subtract protein + fat calories from your target, then ÷ 4 for carb grams.

WORKED EXAMPLE · 80 kg, MUSCLE GAIN**~2,850 kcal****160 g**

Protein · 640 kcal

70 g

Fat · 630 kcal

~395 g

Carbs · 1,580 kcal

Illustrative figures based on common industry patterns — not a specific study. Adjust to your own results.

— BUILD IT ON A PLATE

Building balanced meals

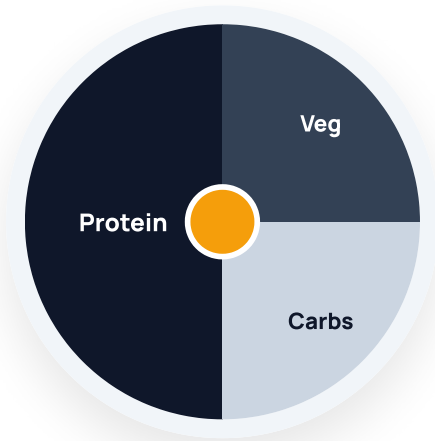
You don't need to weigh every meal forever. The hand-portion method builds a solid plate in seconds — perfect for eating out or when you're short on time.

■ 1 **palm** of protein

■ 1 **fist** of vegetables

■ 1 **cupped hand** of carbs

■ 1 **thumb** of fats



THE SIMPLE MEAL FORMULA

Protein + Vegetable + Smart carb + Thumb of fat = a balanced meal, every time.

— SMALL CHANGES, BIG RESULTS

Food swaps that work

Same meals, different totals. Swap up when you're chasing muscle and need easy calories; swap down when you're leaning out and want to stay full on fewer.

SWAP DOWN · FAT LOSS

Instead of	Choose	You save
Full-fat latte	Skimmed flat white	~120 kcal
Mayonnaise (1 tbsp)	Mustard / light mayo	~80 kcal
Beef mince (20% fat)	Lean mince (5% fat)	~150 kcal
Crisps (bag)	Rice cakes + light cheese	~130 kcal

SWAP UP · MUSCLE GAIN

Instead of	Choose	You add
Water with a meal	Semi-skimmed milk	+150 kcal
Plain porridge	Porridge + peanut butter	+190 kcal
Side salad	Rice + olive oil	+250 kcal

— DECODE ANY PACKAGE

Reading nutrition labels

Marketing lives on the front of the pack. The truth lives on the back. Here's how to read a UK label in ten seconds flat.

Nutrition		
Typical values	Per 100g	Per serving
Energy	385	289 kcal
Fat	6.2g	4.7g
of which saturates	1.1g	0.8g
Carbohydrate	41g	31g
of which sugars	3.4g	2.6g
Fibre	4.1g	3.1g
Protein	11g	8.3g

WHAT TO ACTUALLY CHECK

- ✓ **Serving size first.** Every other number is meaningless until you know the portion.
- ✓ **Energy (kcal) per serving.** This is the number that drives your total.
- ✓ **Protein per serving.** Higher is usually better for fullness and muscle.
- ✓ **Compare per 100g.** The only fair way to judge two products side by side.

Watch out: "low fat" often means "high sugar", and "per serving" can be a fraction of what you'll really eat.

— THE LAST 5%

Hydration & supplements

Get your calories, protein and training right first — that's 95% of the result. Water and a short, evidence-backed supplement list handle the rest.

**Hydration: ~30–35 ml per kg of bodyweight, daily**

Add 500–750 ml around training. Pale-straw urine is your simplest daily check.

SUPPLEMENTS WORTH YOUR MONEY

Supplement	Dose	Why	Evidence
Protein powder	20–40 g as needed	Convenient way to hit your protein target	★★★★★
Creatine monohydrate	3–5 g every day	Most researched aid for strength & muscle	★★★★★
Caffeine	3–6 mg/kg pre-workout	Boosts focus, output & perceived effort	★★★★☆
Vitamin D / omega-3	As directed	Useful top-ups if your diet falls short	★★★☆☆

Evidence ratings are illustrative summaries of common industry consensus — not a specific study. Check with a professional before supplementing.

— AVOID THESE

Common nutrition mistakes

Most people don't need to do more — they need to stop doing these. Fix the leaks and progress takes care of itself.

**Under-eating protein**

Fix: anchor every meal with a palm of protein and hit your daily gram target.

**Weekend blowouts**

Fix: two big days can erase five good ones. Loosen, don't abandon, the plan.

**Drinking your calories**

Fix: juices, lattes and alcohol add up fast and don't fill you up. Prioritise food.

**All-or-nothing thinking**

Fix: one off-plan meal isn't failure. Get back on track at the very next meal.

**Guessing portions**

Fix: track for two weeks to learn what a portion really looks like — then estimate.

**Cutting too hard**

Fix: crash diets kill energy and muscle. A moderate deficit wins every time.

— YOUR STARTING LINE

The action checklist

Don't try to do everything at once. Tick these off one at a time — in order — and you'll have the whole system running within a fortnight.

☐ Estimate your maintenance calories☐ Set a goal: deficit, maintenance or surplus☐ Set your daily protein target (~2 g/kg)☐ Build every meal with the plate method☐ Plan 2–3 go-to meals you actually enjoy☐ Drink ~30–35 ml of water per kg daily☐ Add creatine (3–5 g) if you choose to☐ Weigh in weekly & adjust every 2–3 weeks

Consistency beats perfection. Nail 80% of these, 80% of the time, and your results will speak for themselves.

— YOU'RE READY

Summary & next steps

You now know more about nutrition than most people ever will. Keep it simple, stay consistent, and let these principles do the heavy lifting.

- ✓ Calories decide your weight direction
- ✓ Protein shapes your body composition
- ✓ Carbs & fats fuel and support you
- ✓ Consistency beats any perfect diet

— READY TO GO FASTER?

Let's build your plan together.

This guide is the foundation. With 1:1 coaching you get a plan built around your body, your schedule and your goals — plus the accountability that actually makes it stick.

[Apply for 1:1 Coaching →](#)

or email fitnessforge@gmail.com



— Coach Aaron

FitnessForge · Evidence-based coaching

Stop guessing. Start seeing results in the mirror.

Evidence-based coaching for beginners and intermediate lifters who want a clear, guided path — not another fad.